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‘Like going to a fiesta’ – the role of female fighters in Colombia’s FARC-EP

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Traditionally women and children have been seen as victims rather than protagonists in conflict. However, since the 1970s, women and children have assumed an active role as combatants in Colombian insurgencies. This is especially true of the FARC-EP, which integrates women into its political and military structure in ways that give them a sense of participation, accomplishment and satisfaction. Without their contributions, including sexual services, the FARC could probably not survive. However, despite their favourable experiences, many women ultimately become disillusioned with the FARC’s masculine culture and value system that fails to accommodate their aspirations as women.

Keywords: Colombia; FARC; women

Until recently, women have been virtually invisible in studies of conflict. While female terrorists like Vera Figner, the nineteenth century Russian revolutionary who plotted the assassination of Tsar Alexander II, the Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine’s Leyla Khaled, celebrated for her coolness under pressure, or the Red Army Faction’s Ulrike Meinhof are studied as aberrant representatives of their gender,¹ for the most part scholars of war and professionals engaged in post-conflict stability (SSR) have traditionally viewed women as victims, rather than perpetrators, of violence – displaced, destitute, their families often scattered or murdered, women in conflict zones usually collect in refugee camps or on the margins of cities forced to scrape a living, and mend their shattered lives, as best they can.

And while the view of females as victims of war is especially strong in non-governmental organization (NGO) communities tasked to help them, it is equally certain that targeting women and girls to humiliate and assert dominance over an opponent, and retaliate for damage done is a practice at least as old as the Trojan War. One of the most egregious modern examples occurred during World War II, where the rape of females in the Axis countries of Romania, Hungary and

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especially Germany was openly encouraged in the Red Army by 1945.² The 1993 Vienna Declaration and Program of Action on Human Rights contained a special section on violence against women, who are often incorporated as sex slaves or trophies for alpha males in insurgencies or criminal groups, while hardly a year passes without a report by the United Nations, intergovernmental organizations (IGOs) or NGOs condemning violence against women and children in conflict zones.³

The received view sees men as protagonists of conflict in which women and children are the inevitable victims. Women are viewed as weak, subordinate, and incapable of generating violent acts,⁴ hence their role in combat and their contributions to the efficiency of military organizations, especially in illegal armed groups (IAGs), remains largely unexplored. This is remarkable, as a 2004 study asserts that females were or are present in armed opposition groups in 38 countries. But even while acknowledging female presence in the ranks, female fighters continue to be seen as collateral victims of male violence. Women and girls enlist in rebellions for reasons of ideology, tribal or family solidarity, friendship, a desire for change, or are compelled to serve against their will. However, the overwhelming motive for female enlistment, according to one author, is 'to shield themselves from murder, torture and or abuse by state actors'.⁵

Women and girls have supplied a significant percentage of fighters in the many left-wing armed insurgencies that have blossomed in Colombia since the 1960s.⁶ A 2004 Amnesty International study of sexual violence in the Colombian conflict concluded, even as armed combatants, women are victims of the conflict because the female body has become a 'territory to conquer' for the combatants.⁷ The Colombian Ministry of Defense insists that females who serve in *Fuerzas Armadas Revolucionarias Colombianas – Ejército del Pueblo* (FARC-EP) are among the most flagrant victims of violence. Forced to perform arduous military duties and risk their lives in the service of a criminal cause, they are also treated as virtual sex slaves: 'Communities that are so isolated, such as the FARC camps, have a need for women', insists Sergio Jaramillo, Colombian Deputy Minister of Defense. 'The promiscuity that exists is brutal. In some way, the women are used to keep the men entertained.'⁸ A former US special forces colonel with long experience in Colombia agreed that the female guerrillas were 'just passed around' among their male colleagues, a view shared by Colombian soldiers interviewed for this article who insisted that FARC *guerrilleras* were used for domestic chores and 'as prostitutes' in FARC camps.⁹ When they become pregnant, as many inevitably do, they are forced to abort, often late in their pregnancy, and in horrible conditions.¹⁰

This article does not disagree with the view that women are the victims of violence in conflict in general, and are exploited in the FARC in particular. Indeed, all young persons lured into the ranks of the FARC-EP seriously jeopardize their chances of reaching adulthood.¹¹ However, merely asserting that women and girls in the FARC are victims of violence is unhelpful so long as one

fails to understand why they continue to volunteer to serve in the FARC, and why they insist that they find a degree of fulfillment and satisfaction in their participation in the insurgency. This article will argue that the focus on females as victims of conflict has detracted from a discussion of the reasons for female enlistment in the guerrilla ranks, the contribution female fighters make to the military efficiency of the FARC, and to its resilience and longevity as a political-military organization. 'Victims' seldom make good soldiers, and terror only goes so far in stimulating military performance. Indeed, interviews with demobilized female and male guerrillas of the FARC-EP, as well as Colombian officers and soldiers, carried out by the authors,¹² lead to the conclusion that women serve willingly in the insurgency and number among the FARC's most devoted and efficient combatants. This positive view of their experience is all the more remarkable as interviews with deserters frequently emphasize the negative aspects of their experience in the guerrilla war, in an effort perhaps to ingratiate themselves with their interviewers, and to justify, both to outsiders and in their own mind, their decision to flee the organization.¹³

Even though former guerrillas elect to desert, none of those interviewed, male or female, viewed their initial reasons for enlistment as misguided. On the contrary, the FARC exploits the shortcomings in Colombian rural society – social inequality, the violence of right-wing paramilitary groups, ethnic and racial grievances in Indigenous and Afro-Colombian communities, and lack of education and hence of opportunity, among others. The combination of poverty, lack of education, and limited opportunity and autonomy offered to women in the highly patriarchal Colombian society means that young *campesinas* are particularly vulnerable to FARC recruitment campaigns. In the view of a senior official of International Organization for Migration (IOM), an organization that works with many female victims of the Colombian conflict, 'the sense of hopelessness' of adolescent females in many rural areas of Colombia 'is amazing. They have no dream, no idea that they can succeed in a normal life'. Pregnancy is the only way 'they can reassure themselves of their identity'.¹⁴

If this view is correct, then for many of these young women and girls, the FARC appears as a lifeline. Far from seeing themselves as 'victims' of conflict, former female guerrillas especially look back on their service as an extremely positive experience, for at least two reasons.

First, although discipline in the FARC is strict, and punishment may be brutal, the organization allows females a relative autonomy and a control over their lives – including sexual freedom – unimaginable in the patriarchal rural societies from which the vast majority are recruited. Indeed, for many young females, the FARC offers a sanctuary from physical and verbal, occasionally sexual, abuse, empowers them through arms, assigns defined roles and tasks that allows them a measure of control over their lives. The contrast between the relative freedom and control over their choices in the FARC and the subordinate position held by women in Colombian society makes reintegration into civilian life especially difficult for former *guerrilleras*.

Second, they feel considerable pride in the fact that, without the dedication, organizational skills and courage displayed by females, the FARC could not function with the level of combat proficiency that it has achieved, nor indeed survive as an organization. Service in the FARC gives them a sense of accomplishment and an opportunity to play an important role in what most regard, at least for a time, as a successful enterprise.

It is always possible that these former female fighters may replicate a male veteran's ability to allow reminiscences of a camaraderie born of shared dangers to crowd out memories of the terrors of combat and the crushing tedium and discomfort of military service. However, they resist the categorization of their memories as a 'masculization' of their experience of war. On the contrary, they revel in their service, not because they lived it as did men, but because it allowed them to prove their worth as women.

Furthermore, the reasons that ultimately triggered their desertion were quintessentially female ones. Because, for all of its skill in integrating women into its military system, the FARC has proven unable to reconcile the demands of insurgency with what might be termed a 'family friendly policy'. Indeed, pregnancy, abortion, and the desire to acquire stable relationships are events that ultimately cause females to conclude that service in the FARC is a journey rather than a destination.

Therefore, the premise of this article is that females occupy critical operational, tactical and social roles in the FARC. They may even to be said to comprise the lynchpin of the FARC organization, without whom the FARC could not survive as a rural insurgency. As such, *guerrilleras* comprise a potentially critical vulnerability of the FARC. Yet, beyond blanket declarations that female guerrillas are exploited – assertions that, while true, they appear universally to reject – no concerted effort has yet been made, so far as the authors are aware, by counterinsurgency strategists to target potential female recruits and serving FARC *guerrilleras* with a concerted information-operations campaign.

The goal of this article is threefold: first, to chronicle how a group of former female fighters in the FARC view their collective service in the insurgency; second, to offer an analysis of how the FARC successfully incorporates females into their military system in ways that elicit maximum loyalty and efficiency from them to increase the organizational capacity, resilience and combat efficiency of their insurgency; finally, we analyze the shortcomings of the FARC system so far as females are concerned to ascertain why some women eventually break with the guerrilla organization.

Women in the FARC-EP

While females serve and have served as fighters in all of the illegally armed groups in Colombia since the 1960s, this study will focus on the FARC-EP, which is both the oldest active insurgency in Latin America, and the one which employs the highest percentage of females – between 20% and 40% depending

on the 'fronts' – in its ranks. The FARC emerged from the period known as *La Violencia*, a vicious party war between Liberals and Conservatives that raged in Colombia for a decade after 1948, as die-hard leftists who refused to accept the government amnesty and instead elected to fight on from several so-called independent republics. When a series of government offensives launched in 1962 as part of the US-assisted Plan Lazo overran these insurgent strongholds, the survivors fled into Colombia's limitless jungle and, on 5 May 1966, declared themselves the armed wing of the Colombian Communist Party – the FARC. The movement remained small and isolated until 1982 when it reorganized under its then leader Jacob Arenas and added *Ejército del pueblo* (EP) or 'army of the people' to its title. In 1985, FARC-EP statutes formally recognized women as guerrillas on an equal footing with men.¹⁵ Through involvement in the narcotics trade and other illegal activities like kidnapping, theft, and extortion, the FARC-EP acquired the resources to expand and modernize its military forces. By the late 1990s, the FARC-EP had grown to between 15,000 and 18,000 armed fighters, recruited overwhelmingly in rural areas and small towns, complemented by networks of *milicianos* in the cities. By the turn of this century, Bogotá was virtually besieged by the guerrillas, who also controlled significant areas of the country where they were able to close down public highways and operate with virtual impunity against isolated military posts and police stations.

The advent of the US-sponsored Plan Colombia and the election of Álvaro Uribe as President of Colombia in 2002 added momentum to a military resurgence that allowed the Government of Colombia to seize the strategic initiative from the FARC. A key component of the government's strategy was to expand and fortify the 'Demobilization Project' begun in 1999 by combining a significant psychological operations-capability with offers of cash rewards for information and weapons, amnesty and re-integration into civil society through education programs for guerrillas who willingly surrender. At the time of writing in May 2008, the government claims that fully 15,774 members of IAGs have surrendered under the terms of the Demobilization Project, of which 9,551, or 60.6% are members of the FARC. These former guerrillas offer a rich source of documentation on the experience of female guerrillas in the FARC-EP, upon which this article is based.¹⁶

A core strength of the FARC's military system is to have understood the potential advantages of female presence in their ranks, and to have structured their organization to squeeze maximum benefit from female recruitment. The presence of female fighters offers several benefits for the FARC.

First, it is compatible with the FARC's stated ideological goals. 'The FARC feels that the entire community needs to be represented in its ranks', insists Felipe, a former FARC company commander, and this includes women.¹⁷

Second, female recruitment increases the quantity and quality of the FARC's recruitment pool by bringing into the ranks a group of malleable conscripts who can be fashioned into disciplined and loyal fighters able to fill key roles in the FARC organization.

Third, the courage and efficiency – not to mention ferocity – of female fighters set the gold standard of audacity under fire and serve as an example to their male counterparts.¹⁸

Fourth, females help to soften the image of what is, in reality, a congregation of criminals.¹⁹ Females are often used by the FARC in photo-ops and to interact with civilian populations in areas controlled by the guerrillas, where they look after the interests and safety of women, mediate domestic and community disputes, and look after orphaned or displaced children.²⁰ These vital public relations, social, and judicial functions help the FARC to expand its support base, a strategy vital, in its view, to winning a ‘people’s war’.

Fifth, female presence in the ranks attracts and retains male guerrillas because they provide a supply of sexual partners to what would otherwise compose a corps of forlorn, largely celibate male insurgents tempted to abandon the cause at the first whiff of perfume – indeed, a former FARC commander asserts that, ‘(Female guerrillas) are essential for the morale and stability of the organization.’²¹

A final advantage for the FARC is that the presence of females – and children – in its ranks helps to demoralize and discredit the Colombian military by forcing them to open fire on categories of people normally considered non-combatants, in violation of deeply held cultural and human rights norms.

Motivations for enlistment

Because the FARC recruits in areas where it has a presence, its soldiers are overwhelming rural, frequently illiterate or barely educated, heavily Indigenous or Afro-Colombian, and young – FARC regulations insist that no one under 14 is enlisted, and that 16 to 18 is the most common age of entry, but incorporation of children is common. ‘Tiro Fijo (the former FARC leader) set the recruitment age at 15, but he never respected it’, insists a senior International Organization for Migration (IOM) official who works with former guerrillas. ‘There is a pattern of abuse and neglect (among recruits) and the FARC makes it worse. They have serious psyo-social damage. There is lots of family abuse. They have worked since they were very young, and have little interest in education and difficulties at school.’²² ‘In the countryside, there are often no schools, and there is lots of abuse’, agreed one former FARC company commander. ‘So the people come to the FARC as a sanctuary.’²³ This is especially true of young women. See Table 1 for the educational background of guerrilla demobilized in early 2008.²⁴

For many rural girls, joining the insurgency fulfills a childhood ambition. All those interviewed grew up in areas controlled by insurgent groups, or where these groups were prominent. Lucia remembered that ‘we grew up with the guerrilla. Every day they came to my house... My father knew the (front) commander... (and) sometimes would visit their camps to talk with them, and take us there, so from a young age we started to know the camps and familiarize ourselves with them.’²⁵ Elena, from the largely Afro-Colombian province

Table 1. Education level of guerrillas who demobilized between 1 January and 16 May 2008.

Level	Academic level of demobilized by group ⁱ					%
	FAR C	EL N	Auto-Defense Groups	Others.	Total	
Illiterate	203	34	0	6	243	18.3951551
Primary	268	25	0	2	295	22.3315669
Some Primary	473	49	0	2	524	39.666919
High School Diploma	26	3	0	0	29	2.19530658
Some High School	201	17	0	2	220	16.6540499
University	10	0	0	0	10	0.75700227
TOTAL	1181	128	0	12	1321	100

Source: *Proceso de desmovilización individual: Situación actual*, Bogotá, 19 May 2008.

of Chocó on the Pacific coast, remembered looking upon the female guerrillas who visited her village dressed in uniform and carrying weapons as glamorous figures: 'I like the FARC because I saw these women in uniform, with rifles looking very beautiful. I decided that (when I was old enough) I would have my equipment and a rifle.'²⁶

Leni enjoyed visiting the guerrilla camps as a young girl: 'I had many friends there and many guerrillas came to our house. And I saw they had a good life. And everyone said it was good, because they came and went, had parties, food... Because back then, the guerrilla was like relaxed. But now that the army is everywhere, it's hard.'²⁷ At age 13, Cecelia fell in love with a guerrilla, and then worked in the narcotics trade with the FARC, where she became friendly with the company commander, 'and little by little got close to them'.²⁸

Many guerrillas come from areas where few under 30 remembered what a policeman or school teacher looked like. In this case, uncles and cousins recruited new generations of family into the FARC. 'The guerrillas in Arauca (the oil-rich Colombian province on the Venezuelan border) were the home team', insisted a former US officer with extensive Colombian experience. 'Everyone identified with them.'²⁹

Three of those interviewed were propelled into the guerrilla by an unhappy home situation – their parents separated, passed off to neglectful relatives, objectives of physical or verbal abuse, the guerrilla army appeared to offer stability and friendship. Teresa's life was "very hard, very sad... always beaten, black and blue, black and blue all over!"³⁰ Cristina's father turned her over to the FARC after she reported to the police that he was beating her.³¹ Only one of those interviewed complained that she had been tricked into joining: Ana, with two children to support, claimed that the FARC promised her a salary upon enlistment and that she could visit them once a month, pledges both broken.³²

Statistics on abusive environments as a motivation for enlistment are confusing. For instance, for those guerrillas of both sexes who surrendered between January and April 2006, only 4% interviewed by psychologists attached to the Ministry of Defense's *Programa de Desmovilización Individual* claimed to have unsatisfactory relationships with their families. Most retained good childhood memories, and three-quarters of them maintained contact with their families. However, fully 55% claimed to have been physically and verbally abused as children.³³ But with the exception of Christina, Ana, and Leida, who was conscripted as a child of nine, the women interviewed cited positive reasons for joining the FARC: attraction to weapons; the glamorous appearance of the *guerrilleras*, the promise of travel and adventure, because their friends or family were guerrillas, or because they were already involved in the drug trade as *raspachines* – usually young people whose job is to scrape the coca leaves, an initial step in the processing of coca into cocaine.³⁴ Only two of those interviewed claimed to have any knowledge of the structure or ideology of the FARC prior to enlistment. However, most claimed to have been won over in the daily ideological indoctrination where they were lectured on the values

of the organization, its self-professed commitment to a better society, and were indoctrinated into the principles of gender equality upon which the FARC is allegedly run.

‘Tropical Communism’ – Life in the FARC

Initiation into any military organization is meant to be a shock, aimed at breaking the physical, psychological and emotional bonds with one’s former life. The FARC is no exception. A novice guerrilla takes a *nom de guerre*, and during a two-month basic training course must become familiar with the rituals, values, and regulations of the organization, and adjust to a new set of companions. Novice *guerrilleras* face special challenges because they are required to perform traditionally masculine tasks like cutting wood, standing guard, undertaking long marches carrying heavy loads, digging trenches and latrines, assembling and disassembling a camp, and learning to use camouflage and firing weapons. While most rural Colombians are expected to perform domestic and farm chores from an early age, the relentless demands of campaign life come as a shock, especially to children: ‘My role was to cook’, remembered Leida, an Afro-Colombian forced into the FARC at age nine. ‘It was tough work, practically slavery. Everything was work. We marched and marched until our feet were bloody. None of our leaders showed any humanity, never. The senior commander Ivan Márquez came once to our camp and saved my life by sending me to another front. It didn’t please him when people were mistreated. Some of my friends deserted.’³⁵

But for Leni, the discipline, dangers, and physical hardships of camp life were more than compensated for by the social universe opened by the FARC – new friends, gossip, parties, males vying to sleep with her – like summer camp with rifles. The most frightening adjustment was standing guard at night, alone with the mosquitoes and the noises of the jungle, ‘and rain and rain’, knowing that the lives of her comrades were in her hands. The long marches with backbreaking loads, at the end of which they had to ‘cook the food, cut palm leaves to camouflage the kitchen, cut wood to build a *caleta*...’³⁶ remained among Cecilia’s least pleasant memories.

If the army was on their trail, they would have to sleep in their often wet clothing, and be prepared to pack up camp and leave in the middle of the night. Anything left behind as evidence of guerrilla presence resulted in a punishment. The shock was especially great for Ana whose enlistment coincided with a Colombian military attack that seriously curtailed her basic training – barely eight days in the FARC, she was handed a rifle and, before being tossed into a skirmish, was told if she failed to use it correctly and was killed, then it was her problem.

One of the FARC’s boasts is that it has managed to create a racially and gender neutral organization, where women are treated as equal partners. To a person, the demobilized guerrillas interviewed insist that this is so, and that

women are not discriminated against but are 'free'. Gender equality extends to combat, an activity at which everyone agrees the women excel. Women are assigned combat tasks, like preparing ambushes and harassing missions. They are also in the forefront in firefights: 'There were many women who were very stud (*berracas*), really stud when they fight with the army, more than the guys', Lucia insisted. The bravery of FARC *guerrilleras*, an observation confirmed by Colombian soldiers and male guerrillas – 'a woman is more dangerous than a man' one *desmovilizado* assured us³⁷ – belongs to the generalized phenomenon of women in male-dominated organizations who feel that they must out-perform men to be taken seriously. María Eugenia Vásquez, who became a leader in the M-19, a movement centered in the Colombian public universities in the 1970s and 1980s, insisted that to get the respect of her male colleagues, 'we had to demonstrate constantly that we could do everything asked of us and more'.³⁸ A senior IOM official sees the prominence of women in combat as one more example of the FARC's cynical exploitation of female recruits as cannon fodder, 'a tropical version of communism and the rights of women. These kids have fighting technique. But they don't have a clue about Marxist-Leninism. The FARC has old-fashioned and useless methods of political education.'³⁹

But women appear to see combat as an opportunity to get respect: 'One time', Claudia remembered, 'I told a *guerrillero*: as a *guerrillera* I feel prouder than you, because you are a man, God sent you into this world a stud, and what a man does a woman does here.'⁴⁰ Leni modified this view somewhat: while agreeing that female combat performance exceeded that of males, she noted that some women were very frightened, and shunned combat, which was not her case: 'At least in the 49th (Front) there were lots of women warriors. Many women', including one named Marta whose was 'tough', '*bien agile*' and knew every hill in their area of operation 'like the back of her hand'. 'I liked combat a lot', Leni concluded. For Claudia, combat was a drug, like going to a 'fiesta', especially if the enemy was the hated paramilitaries:

I went into (my first combat) with the machine-gun detachment, because there was no discrimination, armed only with a pistol. But if I had to go empty handed, I would have gone. I'm not afraid to fight, because the smell of powder excites me. I've fought in Antioquia, in Chocó, Urabá [provinces], and never been scared... for me, it's like going to a fiesta. I sing, skip and jump because it makes me happy, fighting.

Fighting a counterinsurgency war, especially in one's own country, is always psychologically taxing. This is made more so in Colombia because of the FARC's profligate use of women and child combatants. Colombian soldiers find the prospect of fighting female and child guerrillas disorienting, infuriating, and ultimately demoralizing. Not only does killing women and children go against every cultural taboo, it also runs contrary to the human rights training and complicates the strict rules of engagement which has become the norm in the Colombian military since the 1990s. One soldier told the authors that he was extremely reluctant to fire on an armed female. Others, aware from bitter

experience that the FARC employs women and children to carry out lethal tasks, were more pragmatic:

It's them or me. One just can't say, "no, it's a woman, don't shoot". Once we saw a kid, maybe 12-year-old, with a rifle that was bigger than he was, and we shouted for him to surrender. The sergeant had a younger brother and ordered us not to shoot because it would be like shooting his brother, because he was very small. And he surrendered. But sometimes they start shooting, and you have to take aim at a kid. And it's very hard to aim at a kid.⁴¹

One policeman remembered an engagement in the Llanos of eastern Colombia during the FARC's 'war of movement' in the 1990s in which 'we collected approximately 150 bodies. The helicopters were full of blood. We put them on the ground and we realized that 70% were kids, 70% or 80% were kids. People came up and said: "They're kids. They're kids." The oldest was maybe 16. Between 14 and 16. Small soldiers, girls and boys.' The soldiers insisted that a favorite FARC tactic was to send 'waves to weaken the army, which has to stop them. The guerrilla leaders send boys and girls 12, 13, 14, 15, 16 years old', with little training or combat skill, while the more experienced guerrillas delay joining the attack until the troops had expended their munitions. But while this tactic had worked well enough in the late 1990s when the Colombian Army was composed mostly of short-service conscripts, it has become suicidal against disciplined professional soldiers backed by a solid logistical system and air support.⁴² The main problem now is the psychological, moral, and legal complications that may emerge from accusations that the Colombian Army has killed non-combatants.⁴³

'Promotion by savagery'⁴⁴

In theory, any guerrilla is able to advance in the FARC hierarchy based on his or her abilities, dedication, and intelligence. But while there are cases of women commanding squadrons or companies, few go much higher, and the 12-man Secretariat is precisely that – all male. There are exceptions, among them Teresa, a former *raspachina*, who caught the eye of FARC commanders when she organized the rescue of two children used by the FARC for intelligence work who had been captured by the army. 'So, they said that I could strategize, and I had everything it took and a month and a half later they made me a leader... and I began to go up and up'.

When women do advance in rank, they carry with them the same fearsome reputation that they gain in combat: 'All the guerrillas are afraid of a female commander', insists Felipe.⁴⁵ And no wonder, if they resemble Nelly Ávila Forero, alias 'Karina', who until May 2008 when she surrendered to Colombian authorities, commanded FARC's Front 47 that, before it was decimated by deaths and defections, numbered roughly 350 'men'. Forty-five years old when she voluntarily surrendered to authorities, 'Karina' had transitioned into the insurgency via the Communist youth movement, where she made her reputation managing the propaganda and communications of her 'front', and for her

ruthlessness. Her dark skin and the fact that she had lost an eye in combat in 1989 added to her piratical allure. 'She was more of a *tropera* (soldier's soldier) than a *comandante* and this went a long way toward motivating her people', according to a former guerrilla.⁴⁶

However, the women interviewed failed to see the absence of females in the FARC leadership as evidence of discrimination. Only Teresa among the women interviewed harbored ambitions to advance up the FARC chain-of-command.⁴⁷ The others had no desire to shoulder responsibility for running a complex organization that requires *comandantes* to manage finances, logistics, plan and direct operations, and administer discipline. When things go wrong, and guerrillas die in combat or desert, commanders may face enquiry and court-martial. And in this respect, the women may reflect the attitude of most of the *guerrilleros*, 'because not everyone possesses the mental structure and only want to stand guard and pass their time that way without ambitions', according to Estaban, an ex-FARC *miliciano*.⁴⁸

Leni agreed that "there are also many disorganized women" who would not make good commanders, young girls often distracted by relationships with the opposite sex, but that in any case, women were not especially interested in promotion. One reason may be that they have to adopt a very tough demeanor to make themselves respected, as Vásquez discovered even among left-wing, university educated men of the M-19: '(Women leaders) gained a reputation for being very hard and authoritarian, but that was the only way we could impose ourselves on the males.'⁴⁹ Dora Margarita, who served as a commander in both the *Ejército de Liberación nacional* (ELN) and the M-19 in the 1980s, was emotionally churned following a particularly bloody battle in which there had been many casualties: 'I couldn't cry. I had men under my command. Therefore I had to demonstrate to them that I was as strong as they, that I wasn't inferior just because I was a woman. I had to make a huge effort to appear that I had the same physical capacity as they. My equipment was as heavy as that of the men. They didn't like being commanded by a woman.'⁵⁰

Failure to seek command may reflect something other than the absence of a 'mental structure' or ambition, however. The fact that the FARC has an MOS (military occupational specialty) system, in many respects circumscribes the female role in the organization, while making women essential to its efficiency and success. Most females are content to occupy the positions that the FARC traditionally assigns women as nurses, radio operators, explosives experts, specialists in logistics and finance, intelligence, propaganda and 'public order'.

The fact that they can master a technical specialty and occupy key positions in the organization which makes them important and respected figures is a source of high morale and satisfaction for FARC females. Women generally earn top marks for their competence and utility, especially as nurses. This builds relationships that can come in useful during a court-martial, for instance. Many FARC commanders allegedly prefer women in their security detachments because they are considered loyal, and probably because they are better able

to sniff out treachery, which has become a real problem for the FARC as the government is making a concerted effort to infiltrate the insurgency with agents, and offer cash rewards to defectors able to locate FARC camps and weapons caches. Lucia was particularly proud of her work as a radio operator, a vital coordinating role that required her to 'receive communications from the other fronts'. She was also used in the 'public order commission' whose job it was to 'talk with the civilians (in FARC dominated villages), explain to them why we fight'. Persuading locals to cooperate with the guerrilla is vital to recruitment, logistics, and obtaining intelligence for the FARC. Women are less threatening and more likely to gain the cooperation of the locals. This justifies the FARC claim to be the 'army of the people', legitimizes its revolutionary vision, and furthers its strategic aims.

Intelligence collection is another skill at which women historically excel, a fact not lost on the FARC. Leni insisted that pretty, well spoken, usually light complexioned *guerrilleras* were selected for intelligence work, because Indigenous and Afro-Colombian women are considered less attractive and lacking in persuasive skills: 'There are many Indian women in the FARC, and they don't know how to speak, or don't bother . . . so we brought pretty women from other fronts, and put them in intelligence.' They enter a town, 'and (the police) see a pretty woman, and say: "Come, let's talk".' Having made friends with a policeman or soldier, they learn the routines and disposition of the garrison to inform an attack plan – and Chucho, a male deserter insisted, leave them in bed with their throats slit.⁵¹ Elena boasted of female skills in intelligence:

because as women we are sociologically prepared and work against the enemy more easily because we don't lack confidence . . . So we send a good-looking woman, flirtatious, with makeup, and she hooks-up with the soldier. The woman is more intelligent than the soldier . . . and he falls in love with her, because she pleases him and he doesn't know she's a *guerrillera*. (Women) are the ones who do this work best.

So, women derive satisfaction from the specialties they acquire and develop in the FARC. Furthermore, influence for women is seldom defined, as it is for males, by a rank. Nicolas, a former company commander, insists that the relatively scarcity of women in the formal hierarchy must not be taken as an indicator of their invisibility, because *guerrilleras* in the FARC use their sexuality to gain power and influence without the headaches of responsibility, or submitting to the drudgery of the FARC's stiff education and training program required for promotion to positions of leadership.⁵² 'Seduction is also the power to dominate', Vásquez insists.⁵³ Competition among the women to be the '*compañera sentimental*' of the male commanders is keen. Felipe agreed: 'Normally, the prettiest girls go with the commanders, because there are advantages – the best beds, uniforms, permissions. So, the women compete to be with the commander.'

Tanja Nimeijer, the Dutch *guerillera* whose diary was captured in an army raid in the Macarena, a mountainous FARC stronghold south of Bogotá, in June 2007, complained that the commandants were the aristocracy of the FARC whose

women were de facto members of the chain-of-command accorded special privileges like a 'staff' job, better food, alcohol or medical treatment especially if she becomes pregnant, the ability to have children and leave them with their families rather than with complete strangers, or the commuting of a court-martial sentence. 'The *comandante*'s woman is a special case', she wrote in her diary, 'and they have certain privileges, always have all the intelligence, and sometimes give orders'.⁵⁴ Estaban agreed that women were attracted to commanders because they had power. But he also stressed that 'a leader without a woman, that's something bad ... (because) the women help him a lot because they are the *comandanteras*'.⁵⁵

Sexual relations

The pivot of FARC success and survivability are centered on the sexual services provided by female guerrillas. While female fighters are free to refuse sex, and rape is a capital offense according to FARC statutes, FARC etiquette requires that '*la compañera* has embraced the revolution ... therefore she must sleep with all her *compañeros*'.⁵⁶ 'The *guerrilleras* must be available' for sexual relations, insists Felipe. This is true even of girls considered underage in civil society because, Felipe points out, once you are a guerrilla, you are treated like everyone else regardless of age.⁵⁷ In any case, the *quiceñera* (15th year) is the threshold of adulthood in the countryside.⁵⁸

Lucia complained that the male guerrillas stood like 'vultures' looking 'for fresh meat' when new, young, inexperienced girls arrived in camp. It may be that a relative shortage of males in some areas impels the enlistment of females.⁵⁹ But in the courtship category, the advantage goes to the ladies – as there are usually two or three males for every female, 'the women have a huge choice', Nicolas points out. However, according to Lucia, limits are placed on promiscuity: 'The woman who asks to sleep with a guy, and tomorrow another, and another the day after, and sweeps through the whole company' may face sanctions 'for confusing the FARC-EP with the Brothel-EP. And they tell them that if you want to earn a diploma as a prostitute, why not remain a civilian?' Leni agreed that *guerrilleras* who changed partners too often 'damaged their reputation' as well as that of the FARC, and were punished with extra duties.

All of the women interviewed insisted that they were never forced into having sex. Leni derided army propaganda campaigns featuring alleged former *guerrilleras* who claimed 'he raped me, he aimed a gun at me', as 'a lie, a lie. Rape doesn't exist, nor is one obliged to have sex. If you don't want to have sex, you just refuse. And if someone comes into your *caleta* and tries to force you, he is judged and shot.'

The sexual imbalance is alleviated somewhat because women are shifted from fronts that are relatively rich in females, and male fighters are allowed to seek sexual partners in communities controlled by the FARC: 'The *guerrillero* likes the civilians', insists Chucho, Leni's companion. That the option of seeking

companionship outside the FARC is denied to *guerrilleras*, troubles them not in the least as they have plenty of in-house suitors. Sexual relations are permitted when the company is in what the FARC calls '*orden cerrado*', or in camp. Because sexual activity must not be allowed to interfere with military duties, many fighting fronts set aside two days a week – often Wednesday and Saturday – known among guerrillas as '*días de mercado*' or 'market days', for sexual relations.

Females in search of romance may find the FARC a disappointing venue, because the *guerrillero* customarily approaches his intended partner with the directness of a gas station attendant: '*¿A dar caleta hoy?*' ('shall we share a bed?'), or '*Camarada. ¿Nos asociamos?*' Liliana López, alias Olga Lucía Marín, a middle-class university student recruited into the FARC in 1981 at age 19 out of the *Juventud Comunista*, found sexual relations in the FARC 'muy complicadas'. In fact, they were not 'complicated' at all, at least not for the guys. 'I was accustomed to a period of gallantry, of courtship. And if you were going to have sexual relations it would be because you felt a desire. I had had sexual relations with boyfriends in the city. But in the guerrilla one initiated a relationship and immediately you had to go to bed. I didn't like that.' But her city gal, 'look at me I'm Sandra Dee, take some time to flirt with me', attitude was severely at odds with the FARC's express-train courtship culture. 'So I felt very lonely.'⁶⁰

'Dora Margarita', who spent six months as an ELN liaison with the FARC in 1982, found that, 'in the FARC, there was a discrimination against women, a type of subterranean rejection because they were trespassing on male turf... the guys frequently changed their *compañera*. Hardly had they finished with one than they would take up with another. It was as if they said: "I'm finished with her, you take her. I enjoyed her. Now it's your turn".' While *guerrilleras* were free to refuse sex, she insisted that those who did so could expect to be saddled with the cooking, wood gathering, and nights of standing sentinel.⁶¹

The detached, practically mechanical, nature of courtship in the insurgency, and the FARC's insistence that emotional attachments must be subordinated to the ideological and operational requirements of the insurgency, its defenders argue, avoids the trauma of the breakup of *novios* that in Colombian civil society can roil personal and family relationships. In theory, the ability to control access to sex accords the commander significant leverage over the conduct of his subordinates. However, in reality, managing sexual relations is one of the most challenging tasks faced by a commander, who must give permission for guerrillas to take a '*sociola de caleta*' or 'bed mate', for the evening. In the formation, the commander announces that: 'Soldier X has permission. Bed check is prohibited.'⁶² Permission might be refused if the couple's association undermines military discipline or the precepts of the FARC – for instance, Nicolas refused permission to couples who argued frequently, which might be a sign of jealousy, or that a couple had developed emotional ties which might lead to desertion.⁶³ In the latter case, one partner is usually posted to another 'front', and the reaction of each is recorded to ascertain their commitment to the revolution.⁶⁴

But jealousy among teenage combatants is frequent, and shifting relationships can leave lots of hurt pride, especially if the *guerrillero* has a wandering eye, and ‘does the rabbit’.⁶⁵ ‘There are lots of jealous women, because there are lots of *guerrilleras*’, insists Leni. ‘This is especially true when your *socio* decides to sample the wares elsewhere.’⁶⁶ Even Tanya, while in a sanctioned relationship with one guerrilla, lusted to sleep with another. ‘I can’t stay with the same guy for too long’, she admitted.⁶⁷ In which case, the couple ‘opens’ – that is, breaks up. But not without bad feelings that, in the violent and armed world of the FARC, might invite a stray bullet in a firefight, according to ‘Chucho’.

The guiding principle for commanders is that shifting relationships are good for the organization, if not for the *la guerrillera* – ‘If (*la guerrillera*) went with many men in civilian life, she would be considered a prostitute’, Nicolas insists.⁶⁸ He forgot to add that at least she would be paid! But apart from any calculated policy to separate couples who become emotionally involved, or as a test to see if a guerrilla being groomed for a leadership position places loyalty to the organization above that to his or her partner, the constant transfer of personnel between companies and fronts makes stable relationships almost impossible to maintain. ‘You have to respect each other’, says Leni. ‘He’s your *socio*, you’re his *socia*. But when the order to transfer comes, you have to leave.’

Eugenia Vásquez insists that those who accuse female guerrillas of promiscuity miss the point: ‘sexual relations lose the transcendence that society confers on them and become an expression of the proximity between people identified with the same ideals.’ By sleeping with guerrillas, *guerrilleras* signal that they assume an active role in the organization. Even as a leader, Vásquez used sex as a control mechanism: ‘I seduced those who were under my orders, because it pleased me that they saw me as a woman or, perhaps, because the space for flirting was so restricted in this limited universe.’⁶⁹

While association between members of the opposite sex is encouraged, the FARC holds a surprisingly petit bourgeois abhorrence of homosexuality, which is considered a threat to revolutionary discipline – Felipe witnessed two male couples executed by firing squad, a method of discipline used with callous frequency in the FARC. However, when reports reached him that he had two lesbians in his company, he simply posted one to another front, and punished the other with extra duties.

Those who have sexually transmitted diseases (STDs), like HIV, pose a special challenge: ‘No one talks of it. It is kept very secret’, Felipe recounts. But he was probably kidding himself, as was Leni who told us that STDs were not a problem because everyone was given regular medical check-ups. ‘Here we have two *compañeros* with AIDS, and maybe more’, Tanja Nimeijer noted in her diary in June 2006. ‘No one uses condoms. Until now, the girl didn’t understand what this means. She gave me the news with a smile, and her boy friend isn’t especially concerned. A third girl, who has had relations with this guy, is very depressed.’⁷⁰ Given the controlled promiscuity of the FARC, sexual diseases pose a conundrum for the commander, for if the problem is ignored, infections spread.

‘On the other hand’, Felipe recounts, ‘revolutionary practice prohibits the creation of a special category of exclusion.’ The solution is to devise a ‘suicide mission’ for the infected person.⁷¹

The final problem posed by the promotion of revolutionary promiscuity is pregnancy. No woman interviewed thought the prohibition on pregnancy unfair: ‘A child undermines the morale of the guerrilla, who abandons the love of the revolution for the love (of the child)’, Marta believes. ‘If a woman gets pregnant, it’s the fault of the company commander’, Felipe explains, for failing to supervise his troops. Each company has five-person committee, including a ‘logistics’ person whose job among others is to make sure that the females are given contraceptive injections. However, a combination of operational pressures which may make periods irregular or suppress them altogether,⁷² out-of-date drugs and inattention means that ‘many’ *guerrilleras* become pregnant.⁷³ FARC policy is that they be required to abort in the first four months, although a commander also has the latitude to allow the pregnancy to go to term – a privilege more often extended to his *compañera sentimental* – after which the baby is given away. But Leni insisted that late-term abortions were common, for at least two reasons: sometimes *guerrilleras* are afraid to confess their pregnancy for fear of punishment, which was the case of Cecilia who went into battle six months pregnant ‘with my belly sticking out and could hardly do a thing’.⁷⁴ Others keep the secret for as long as possible in the hopes that they will be sent to a town to have their baby, from which they can desert. Leni spoke of a woman whose pregnancy was revealed in the eighth month because she could no longer tolerate the corset she wore to hide it. The revelation of a late-term pregnancy is taken by the FARC as evidence of a desertion plan. **The punishment is to give guerrilleras seven or eight months pregnant massive doses of Citotec or Norplant to induce an abortion.**

While those interviewed were divided on whether they were traumatized by abortion, all agreed that pregnancy, and especially the birth of a child, changed their attitude to the organization. Armando and Sarrias discovered that, at the very least, abortion and/or separation from a child leads to low morale, hostility toward commanders, which may prompt a court martial or desertion.⁷⁵ ‘The guerrilla was very good to me, but when I had a child, my attitude changed a lot’, remembered Susana. ‘I had to think of the baby. What happens if the father is killed, or I die, who’s going to take care of this creature? He’s not going to know his mother or father. So I wrapped him up and fled.’⁷⁶

Demobilization

If so many of these women apparently retain such good memories of life in the FARC, why do they desert? One answer is that they appear to desert at rates lower than their numbers in the force.⁷⁷ Why this is true is unclear. It could indicate a general rate of satisfaction with life in the FARC, or the absence of alternatives. A psychologist who interviews demobilized guerrillas in Bogotá notes that ‘women are especially afraid to demobilize’.⁷⁸ The prospect of leaving

the M-19 after 18 years left Eugenia Vásquez, ‘paralyzed with a fear of the unknown . . . because I would have to make my own decisions and I didn’t know how.’ She had to learn to live on her own, without a cause, ‘a leader in the field without troops or a battle to fight. I felt free and empty.’⁷⁹ For FARC guerrillas, the risks of recapture are great, especially in areas where the FARC maintains networks of informers, and the punishment is usually death. The same fate awaits them, several insist, if they fall into the hands of the paramilitaries, or even the Army.

And desert to where? It is impossible to return to families who live in areas controlled by the insurgency, while the prospect of seeking safety and anonymity in a city frightens those from rural areas, poorly educated, and who lack the skills to survive in an urban environment – which is all of them.⁸⁰ Guerrillas of indigenous background are considered tainted by interaction with non-indigenous society, and are welcomed back in their communities only after they have undergone lengthy purification rituals, ‘which pisses them off, so they leave’.⁸¹ Rural Afro-Colombian communities are so dirty-poor that the guerrilla life becomes a transit station to immigration to the city. In 2008, there is still no targeted information-operations campaign to encourage female guerrillas to desert.⁸²

Those who elect to desert do so for many of the same reasons as male guerrillas. Life in the guerrilla ranks has become increasingly difficult since 2001. A combination of the political will to take the war to the FARC, a coherent government ‘Democratic Security’ strategy which is basically a ‘clear – hold – build’ approach, and the means to do so supplied by the US-backed Plan Colombia and its successor, the Andean Defense Initiative, have put the Colombian military on a sustained offensive which has pushed the insurgents out of many of their historic strongholds in the center of the country and into the sparsely populated jungle along the Pacific coast and in the south and southeast of the country. Demobilized guerrillas complain that military pressure keeps them constantly on the move during the day, and awake at night.⁸³ Others cite disillusionment with the criminality, corruption, and brutality of the FARC – ‘I saw the lie’, Chucho told us.

But women especially complain that, despite its claims to gender equality, the FARC fails to accommodate their ambitions as females, but instead punishes them. Olga Lucía Marín complained that FARC’s proclamations of gender equality since 1985 have done little to reshape the organization’s culture – for example, the *guerrillera* is not expected to express an opinion different from that of her *compañero sentimental* in a meeting.⁸⁴ And although women are expected to make themselves available for sex, when they get pregnant, the FARC’s priorities come first: After her superiors forced her to undergo a painful, bloody, risky late-term abortion, an angry and traumatized Cristina realized that, ‘the truth is that the death of someone doesn’t bother them’.⁸⁵

Three months after her child was born, Marta was told she had to surrender it: ‘I was crying and they posted me to another squadron so I would have to give up

the baby . . . But I didn't go. I won't give up the kid to anybody, so I didn't give him up. Without the kid, I'm not going.'⁸⁶ Those who have children complain at separation, of having to surrender their children to strangers, and then being exiled to distant fronts where they cannot see them. When Leni, by then serving as a *miliciana*, was ordered to send her 13-year-old daughter into the FARC, 'we sold the chickens and took a motorbike north (from Putumayo, [the southern border river of Colombia]) in the dead of night. I wanted her to study.'

But even without a child, women interviewed complained that the pleasures of life in the jungle were exaggerated, and they pined to strike up stable relationships. 'To be a woman in war represented the renunciation of power', Vásquez insists. 'I gave up my personal life for the collective interests . . . until I became empty and offered my body to the desires of whoever came by.'⁸⁷ Couples who meet in the FARC sometimes desert together so they can continue their relationship, as was the case of Nicolas, and Leni and Chucho. Others complain that they miss their families, and the FARC refused to allow visits.

Conclusion

The foundation of the FARC's appeal is that it holds out 'the emancipatory ideal' to people in areas with little state presence, whose family life is fractured and dysfunctional, whose limited education and skills, ethnic or racial background, or gender severely constricts their opportunities for a normal life. To these, the FARC claims to offer security, a vocation, and a role in the creation of a more just society.⁸⁸ This is especially true for women and girls, for whom the FARC provides an asylum that allows them autonomy, including sexual freedom, an opportunity to prove their worth, and the structure and predictability of an organization with rules. In practically every case, the women interviewed were uniformly positive about their experience in the insurgency.

There were resentments, however, among them a feeling that the FARC required them to abandon their femininity and become like men to succeed in the FARC's military system. 'Cecilia' said that 'one has to become like a man' to be successful in the guerrilla army. Teresa, too, resented the fact that women were forced to adopt 'a masculine role' by going into combat because 'in some cases the men let the women do the fighting', an observation confirmed by Colombian soldiers who noted that the women sometimes remained in the skirmish even after their male colleagues had faded back into the jungle.⁸⁹ She felt that while women should work politically to advance the revolution, combat should be the preserve of men: 'It's a privilege to be a woman and we shouldn't be treated like that . . . One should guard her privacy as a woman, and this would advance feminism.'

But on closer inspection, women felt that they were more successful than men in the FARC, not just because they imitated men, but because they

possess particularly feminine qualities vital to the success of the organization that make them more complete combatants. Although not physically as strong as men, they proved themselves at least the equal of males in traditional warrior tasks like combat, an assertion readily conceded by their former enemies. Meanwhile their organizational, diplomatic, public relations, and intelligence collection skills, essential to the success of the FARC, were in their judgment superior to those of men. The female guerrillas see their body as a weapon, like an AK-47. It is a bonus, not a source of shame, and offers another way in which they contribute to the success of the organization in ways that men cannot. The roles and functions they adopted in the organization gave them status and respect.

Indeed, re-insertion into society proved difficult for many because they were expected to reassume the subordinate role traditionally expected of Colombian women. Teresa complained that re-integration was difficult for former *guerrilleras* in a Colombian society where, 'the man gives orders, where the man imposes his laws . . . I am accustomed to giving orders . . . so it's difficult for us'.⁹⁰ Finally, the sexual services they provide are seen as essential to the stability and morale of the organization. Far from being a source of shame, they see it as a revolutionary duty, and evidence of their commitment to the cause.

However, the organizational culture of the FARC has its limitations for women, even for those whose horizons are as restricted as those of the *campesinas* they recruit. Although the FARC has devised ways to give women in their ranks a sense of fulfillment and accomplishment in the short term, ultimately a woman pays a high price for joining the insurgency. For, in the final analysis, the FARC requires a woman to become what she is not to succeed in the organization, to surrender her identity as a woman. The high risks of STDs, pregnancy, and abortion, the inability to have children, to form stable relationships, and to be with family ultimately trumps the appeal of a career as a 'professional revolutionary'. Vásquez believes that the problem is that machismo is the inherent condition of all armies, and that even revolutionary organizations in Colombia reflect the culture: while,

men recognized the operational capabilities of some *compañeras*, they conceded some advances, but in the intimate category our *compañeros* behaved, for the most part, like Colombian men. We, the *compañeras*, paid a high price to innovate and transgress the norms of matrimony, affection and sexuality. We were left alone, because the men never thought of us as wives . . . we were the perfect lovers, but not people to share a long-term relationship, even less if we had leadership positions.⁹¹

Unfortunately, disillusionment and desertion among *guerrilleras* has failed to knock the FARC out of the game, because, so far, the organization continues to tap into a deep recruitment pool of gullible, abused, or otherwise disadvantaged females to replace those who walk out the door, or who are shot trying. A greater effort is required to convince young females that enlistment in the FARC is not 'like going to a fiesta'. Rather, as Cristina learned, 'the truth is that the death of someone doesn't bother them'.

Notes

1. Figner, *Memoirs of a Revolutionist*; Meinholf, *Everybody Talks about the Weather... We Don't*. The Writings of Ulrike Meinholf; Dittfurth, *Ulrike Meinholf*; and Smith and Moncourt, *Daring to Win: The Red Army Faction's 1977 Campaign of Desperation*.
2. Merridale, *Ivan's War: Life and Death in the Red Army, 1939–1945*, chapter 9: 'Despoil the Corpse'; Anonymous, *A Woman in Berlin. Eight Weeks in a Conquered City* (New York: Metropolitan Books, 2005).
3. Office of the High Commissioner on Human Rights, World Conference on Human Rights, 14–25 June 1993, Vienna, Austria; <http://www.unhchr.ch/html/menu5/wchr.htm>; Resolution 1994/45. Integrates the rights of women into the human rights mechanisms of the United Nations and calls for the elimination of violence against women. [http://www.unhchr.ch/Huridocda/Huridoca.nsf/\(Symbol\)/E.CN.4.RES.1994.45.En?Opendocument](http://www.unhchr.ch/Huridocda/Huridoca.nsf/(Symbol)/E.CN.4.RES.1994.45.En?Opendocument); See for instance *Kosovar Civil Society Report to the United Nations on Violence against Women*, [www.UN.org/womenwatch/daw/vaw/gogcontributeKosovar%20Gender%20Studies%](http://www.UN.org/womenwatch/daw/vaw/gogcontributeKosovar%20Gender%20Studies%20)
4. Ramirez, 'Mujer y Violencia', in *Mujer, Amor y Violencia: Nuevas interpretaciones de antiguas realidades*, 112.
5. Countries in which women serve or have served as fighters in armed opposition groups: *Africa* – Angola, Burundi, Democratic Republic of the Congo, Eritrea, Ethiopia, Ivory Coast, Liberia, Mozambique, Rwanda, Sierra Leone, Somalia, South Africa, Sudan, Uganda; *Latin America* – Colombia, El Salvador, Guatemala, Honduras, Mexico, Peru; *Asia*: Cambodia, East Timor, Indonesia, India, Myanmar, Nepal, Philippines, Sri Lanka, Uzbekistan; *Europe* – Bosnia-Herzegovina; Ireland, Macedonia, Yugoslavia; *Middle East* – Iran, Iraq, Israel, Lebanon, Turkey. Muzurana, 'Women in Armed Opposition Groups Speak on War, Protection and Obligations under International Humanitarian and Human Rights Law', 25–6.
6. Most of the studies that chronicle female participation in illegal armed groups in Colombia are made up of interviews, with little analysis, among them: Botero, *Últimas noticias de la Guerra*; Zuluaga, *Guerrilleras FARC-EP: Crónicas y testimonios de guerra*; Salvie, *Las mujeres en la guerra*; Uribe, *Los niños de la guerra*; Peralta and Patiño, *¿Valió la pena? Testimonios de excombatientes en la vida civil*; Vera Grabe, *Razones de vida*; María Eugenia Vásquez, *Escrito para no morir: Bitácora de una militancia*
7. 'With their bodies viewed and treated as territory to be fought over by the warring parties, women are targeted for a number of reasons – to sow terror within communities making it easier for military control to be imposed, to force people to flee their homes to assist acquisition of territory, to wreak revenge on adversaries, to accumulate "trophies of war", and to exploit them as sexual slaves. Sexual violence has thus indelibly marked Colombian women's lives.' Amnesty International, 'Colombia: "Scarred Bodies, Hidden Crimes": Sexual Violence Against Women in the Armed Conflict', AMR 23/040/2004, <http://www.amnesty.org/en/library/asset/AMR23/040/2004/en/dom-AMR230402004en.html>
8. Jenny Carolina Gonzales, 'Colombian Guerrilla Group Forces Women Fighters to Have Abortions, Defectors Say', *McClatchy Newspapers*, 11 February 2008.
9. Interview no. 1 with senior State Department official, US Embassy, Bogotá, 27 June, 2008; interview with six soldiers, *Escuela de infantería*, Bogotá, 11 July 2008.
10. 'El testimonio de reinsertada: En las FARC vi fusilar mujeres en estado de gestación', *Ejército nacional*, <http://www.ejercito.mil.co/index.php?idcategoria=190231>.
11. The Colombian military estimates the average life expectancy of a FARC guerrilla in 2008 at two years from date of enlistment. Interview with Gen. Mario Montoya, Commander-in-Chief of the Colombian Army, Bogotá, 20 August 2008.

12. Many of the quotations are taken from Natalia Herrera, 'Las mujeres como sujetos activos: una aproximación desde el conflicto armado colombiano', MA thesis, University of the Andes, Social Sciences Faculty, Department of Political Science, Bogotá, May 2007. Other quotations are taken from interviews carried out by the authors in 2008 in Bogotá and Cali. Quotations taken from published sources are noted. The names used are aliases to protect the identity of the interviewees.
13. On the other hand, the difficulties of re-insertion into civilian life, anger and fear of failure may promote more favorable memories of life in the insurgency among those who abandoned it. Colombian scholars José Armando and Cárdenas Sarrias found that, after a few weeks in the demobilization program, wracked with doubts and uncertainties about their future, many former insurgents, especially commanders, speak with nostalgia about a past in which they were armed, issued and followed orders, and felt that they had some control over their future. Armando and Sarrias, *Los parias de la guerra, Análisis del proceso de desmovilización individual*, 117–18.
14. Interview with senior IOM official, Bogotá, 2 July, 2008.
15. 'The duties and rights in the FARC-EP are equal for all of its members without petit bourgeois inequality', Artículo 8/G, *Estatuto de las Fuerzas Armadas Revolucionarias de Colombia Ejercito Del Pueblo (FARC-EP)* without date or place of publication. Trans. D. Porch.
16. *Proceso de desmovilización individual. Situación actual*, Bogotá 19 May 2008. Statistics supplied to the authors by the Programa de Desmovilización Individual. These do not include the 'Collective Demobilization' of roughly 31,000 members of the Autodefensas Unidas de Colombia (AUC) carried out under the Ley de justicia y paz between 2002 and 2006. Of 1181 FARC guerrillas who demobilized between 1 January and 16 May 2008, 250 or 21% were female.
17. Interview with Felipe, former member of the PCCC (Clandestine Colombian Communist Party) and FARC company commander, Bogotá, 3 June 2008.
18. For instance, the Peruvian insurgent group *Sendero Luminoso* believed that, on the whole, women were more loyal and committed to that organization than were men. Kirk, *Las Mujeres de Sendero Luminoso*, 9.
19. For a discussion of how women soften the image of an authoritarian movement, see: Goedde, *GIs and Germans: Culture, Gender and Foreign Relations, 1945–1949*.
20. In 2007, Colombia had 4 million displaced persons, many of them women and children. 'Cuatro millones de desplazados por violencia y conflicto armado en Colombia se registraron en 2007', *El Tiempo*, 17 April 2008.
21. Felipe interview.
22. Interview with IOM official, Bogotá 2 July 2008.
23. Interview with Nicolas, a former FARC company commander, Cali, 4 June 2008.
24. Education level of guerrillas who demobilized between 1 January and 16 May 2008. *Proceso de desmovilización individual: Situación actual*. Bogotá 19 May 2008.
25. Lucia interview, Bogotá, 27 April 2007.
26. Elena interview, Bogotá, 7 May 2007.
27. Leni interview Cali, 4 June 2008.
28. Cecelia interview, Bogotá, 9 May 2007.
29. Interview no. 2 with senior intelligence official, US Embassy, Bogotá, 5 June 2008.
30. Teresa interview Bogotá, 3 May 2007.
31. Cristina interview, Bogotá, 9 May 2007.
32. Ana interview, Bogotá, 1 April 2007.
33. Graficas de las Valoraciones Integrales Enero April 2006, Colombian MoD, Programa de Desmovilización Individual. One claimed to have been sexually abused as a child.

34. Indeed, in rural areas of Colombia, those already involved in planting, harvesting, or processing drugs have proved a fruitful source of recruitment for the FARC. 'De raspachines a guerrilleros: así recultan menores en el Catatumbo', *El Tiempo online*, 21 May 2008.
35. Interview with Leida, Bogotá, 23 August 2006.
36. A *caleta* is basically a platform with a roof covered with leaves and plastic in which the guerrillas sleep.
37. 'Ay, terrible! Bloodthirsty. Very bloodthirsty. They have an impressive composure. But they are more cold blooded than the men.' Interview with Col. Juan Luis Gutiérrez, former commander of 14th Mobile Brigade, 27 May 2008, Bogotá. Quotation from a male former guerrilla present at the Leni interview. Trans. D. Porch.
38. Perdomo, *Escrito para no morir: Bitácora de una militancia*, 277.
39. Interview with IOM official, Bogotá, 2 July 2008.
40. Claudia interview, 8 May 2007.
41. Interview with six soldiers, *Escuela de infantería*, Bogotá, 11 July 2008.
42. Ibid.
43. The Colombian military operates under rules of engagement that restrict their ability to fire on insurgents except under strict conditions of self-defense. Every skirmish in Colombia is treated as a crime scene, and in theory must be investigated by the Colombian equivalent of the district attorney or investigating magistrate. Many in Colombia, including Lt. Col. Juan Carlos Gomez, responsible for human rights in the Colombian MoD, point out that this gives enormous advantages to the enemy, because too few investigating officers exist to check out the site of a skirmish, usually in remote areas, while the Army, in the midst of mobile operations, simply cannot remain in a precarious situation to 'preserve evidence'. Hence, a favorite FARC tactic is to drag soldiers, especially those whose counterinsurgency tactics are proving successful, into court on charges of human rights violation based on the 'testimonies' obtained under threat from 'witnesses to the crime'. A soldier accused of human rights violations in the course of combat is obliged to pay for his own legal defense.
44. IOM interview.
45. Felipe interview.
46. 'Katrina' only came to public attention in June 2002 when her force incinerated 13 policemen and four civilians, including one police spouse, in the village of Pensilvania (Caldas). By that time, according to Colombian authorities, she had amassed a combat record in the 1990s of massacring villagers *pour encourager les autres* to submit to FARC control, assassinating and kidnapping prominent Colombians, including President Álvaro Uribe's father who died in a bungled kidnapping attempt in 1993, and managing her front's significant cocaine trade. Her specialty, however, was personally executing truck drivers unfortunate enough to drive into a FARC roadblock. 'Karina cansada de guerra', *El Tiempo online*, 21 May 2008.
47. Unwillingness to seek promotion is common among both sexes in the FARC. Few recruits have the educational qualifications for promotion and are reluctant to assume the responsibilities of a commander. Armando and Sarrias, *Los parias de la guerra*, 168.
48. Ibid., 188.
49. Vásquez, *Escrito para no morir*, 277.
50. Salvie, *Las mujeres en la guerra*, 63.
51. Chucho interview, Cali, 3 June 2008.
52. Interview with 'Nicolas', Cali, 4 June 2008.
53. Vásquez, *Escrito para no morir*, 278.

54. 'La mujer de un comandante es una clase aparte que ellas tienen ciertos privilegios, siempre tienen toda la información, y a veces dan órdenes.' Pobres niños europeos jugando a la guerra . . . <http://www.denunciando.com/showthread.php?t=25673>.
55. Armando and Sarrias, *Los parias de la guerra*, 188.
56. Ibid., fn 50, 267. According to Nicolas, the common phrase is: 'In the guerrilla, *la guerrillera* screws at least four times a day.' (En la guerrilla, no hay día que la guerrillera no coge menos que quatre veces.)
57. FARC logic means that same disciplinary sanctions are applied to children as to adults, which means that they are subject to court martial and execution. Interview with Leida, Bogotá, 23 August 2006.
58. Interview with 'Nicolas', Cali, 4 June, 2008.
59. 'There were also many women in the Aurelio Rodríguez front. Because in this zone on the frontier between Antioquia and Chocó, in the coffee growing villages of Belén de Umbria, Mistrató, Pueblo Rico, there are many women. I can't say why, but there are lots. So, many join the guerrilla. When we looked at the Aurelio Rodríguez front, there were around 30 or 40 women. Most of them young. Very young . . . girls of 15 or 16.' Interview with Col. Juan Luis Gutiérrez, Bogotá, 27 May 2008. Trans. D. Porch. In many remote, impoverished areas where the guerrillas operate, working age males emigrate, leaving behind a population of women, children and old people. *Colombia: violencia y democracia. Comisión de estudios sobre la violencia*, 193.
60. Lara, *Las mujeres en la guerra*, 106–7.
61. Ibid., 65.
62. 'El regular X tiene permiso. Prohibido revisarle la caleta.' Leni interview.
63. For instance, if she is washing his uniform, or taking him his breakfast in his *caleta*, indications of 'petite bourgeois' behavior and departure from revolutionary norms. Armando and Sarrias, *Los parias de la guerra*, 176.
64. Those being groomed for high command might be separated from their partner to test their loyalty to the revolution. Ibid., 168.
65. Leni interview.
66. 'estar picando en otra parte'.
67. 'Pobres niños europeos jugando a la guerra', 23 August 2006. One guerrilla confessed to Armando and Sarrias that his feelings were seriously hurt when his *socia de caleta* told him that she had a crush on another guerrilla and ask him to help her conquer him, *Los parias de la guerra*, 176.
68. The common phrase is: 'En la guerrilla, no hay día que la guerrillera no coge menos que cuatros veces.'
69. Vázquez, *Escrito para no morir*, 126, 278.
70. 'Aquí hay dos compañeros con sida, y quizás hay más. Aquí nadie usa preservativo. Hasta donde yo entiendo, la chica no sabe lo que esto significa; me contó la noticia todo sonriente, y su amigo, al parecer, no está muy preocupado. Una tercera chica, la cual había tenido relaciones con ese tipo, está bien deprimida.' Pobres niños europeos jugando a la guerra . . . <http://www.denunciando.com/showthread.php?t=25673>.
71. Leni insisted that STDs were not a problem in the FARC because there were regular medical checks.
72. Vázquez, *Escrito para no morir*, 199.
73. Leni interview.
74. Interview, 12 May 2007.
75. Armando and Sarrias, *Los parias de la guerra*, 176.
76. Interview with Susana, Bogotá, 7 May 2007. In the interest of full disclosure, Susana was a member of the *Ejército de liberación nacional* (ELN). But her attitude would be typical of women in the FARC.

77. For instance, in 2007, 135, or 16.4%, of 822 FARC insurgents who demobilized voluntarily were female. Ministerio de defensa, Programa de atención humanitaria, Balance desmovilización 2007, slide 24. Data provided to authors. These do not include the 'Collective Demobilization' of roughly 31,000 members of the *Autodefensas Unidas de Colombia* (AUC) carried out under the *Ley de justicia y paz* between 2002 and 2006. The percentage of demobilized female FARC guerrillas seem to have risen slightly in the first four and one-half months of 2008 – of 1181 FARC guerrillas who demobilized between 1 January and 16 May 2008, 250 or 21% were female. *Proceso de desmovilización individual. Situación actual*. Bogotá, 19 May 2008. Statistics supplied to the authors by the Programa de Desmovilización Individual. Of course, these are figures for those who decide to enter the Demobilization Program. Others may choose to desert without benefit of government protection, or be betrayed or apprehended and shot by the FARC.
78. Interview with Libia Romero, Bogotá, 23 August 2006.
79. Vásquez, *Escrito para no morir*, 354.
80. Ibid. Among the complaints recorded by the demobilized guerrillas: 'They hate this city of cement . . . Bogotá is very large, very cold.' 'Three were killed by buses. They didn't see it coming.'
81. IOM interview.
82. A television spot that depicts a guerrillera undergoing a gruesome, late-term abortion while a FARC commander points a pistol at her was prepared in 2008, but was aimed more at dissuading young women from enlisting in the insurgency, as most insurgents do not have access to television.
83. They especially fear air attack from Colombian Air Force Fantasmas, armed with forward-looking infrared sensors which allows them to locate camps through heat emissions or by coordinates provided by infiltrators sent by Colombian intelligence, then fix them with lasers that guide Embraer EMB 314 Super Tucano fighter-bombers whose pilots are equipped with night vision goggles, to the target. This technique allowed the Colombian military to kill the FARC number two commander, Raúl Reyes, on 1 March 2008 in his camp in Ecuador.
84. Lara, *Las mujeres en la guerra*, 114–15.
85. Cristina interview.
86. Marta interview.
87. Vásquez, *Escrito para no morir*, 355–6.
88. Armando and Sarrias, *Los parias de la guerra*, 163.
89. Interview with six soldiers, *Escuela de infantería*, Bogotá, 11 July 2008.
90. Teresa interview, 3 May 2007.
91. Vásquez, *Escrito para no morir*, 357.

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